

Website Launch Checklist

A practical pre-launch and post-launch checklist for taking a website from “looks finished” to actually ready for real visitors, search engines, forms, analytics, and day-to-day use.

How to use this: Work through it with the people who own the content, design, development, marketing, and business operations. A launch is not complete just because the homepage loads. The real test is whether the site works for visitors, generates the right data, handles edge cases, and can be maintained after release.

One useful rule

Do not ask only “Does it work?” Ask “What happens when someone does the wrong thing, uses a phone, has a slow connection, blocks scripts, submits an incomplete form, lands on an old URL, or needs an accessible way to complete the task?”

Release owner: _____ Target launch date: _____

Revision: September 2026

1. Content and page readiness

A technically perfect website can still fail at launch because the copy, calls to action, contact details, or page relationships are unfinished.

	Checklist item
☐	Every production page has a clear purpose and a specific primary action.
☐	Page titles, headings, body copy, prices, offers, addresses, phone numbers, hours, and service descriptions have been proofread.
☐	Placeholder text, lorem ipsum, sample names, demo images, staging notes, and internal comments are gone.
☐	The navigation reflects the pages that actually exist; no menu item leads to a dead end.
☐	Calls to action say what will happen next. "Submit" is used only when the context already makes the result obvious.
☐	Contact information is consistent everywhere it appears.
☐	Legal, privacy, cookie, accessibility, shipping, refund, or other required notices are published where appropriate for the business.
☐	All downloadable files open correctly and are the intended version.

2. URLs, redirects, and crawlability

Search engines and users should be able to discover the right pages and arrive at the right URL even when an old link is used.

	Checklist item
☐	The production domain resolves correctly over HTTPS.
☐	Preferred host/version is clear (for example, www vs. non-www) and redirects are intentional.
☐	HTTP-to-HTTPS redirects work without chains or loops.
☐	Important old URLs have 301 redirects to the closest relevant current URL when URLs have changed.
☐	There are no accidental 200-status pages that are actually error pages.
☐	Custom 404 page is helpful, branded, and gives the visitor a path back into the site.
☐	robots.txt exists only if it is useful and does not block pages or resources that search engines need to access.
☐	XML sitemap is valid, contains the intended canonical URLs, and is available at the expected URL.
☐	The sitemap is submitted or otherwise made discoverable in the search engine tools the business uses.
☐	Staging, preview, development, or temporary subdomains are not unintentionally indexable.

3. On-page SEO and indexability

Launch QA is the right time to catch SEO mistakes that are otherwise easy to overlook.

	Checklist item
☐	Every indexable page has a useful, unique title and a clear main heading.
☐	Meta descriptions are written for people and match the page; they are not stuffed with repeated keywords.
☐	Canonical tags point to the intended representative URL where canonicalization is needed.

	Checklist item
☐	No important page accidentally carries noindex, nofollow, or conflicting robots directives.
☐	Internal links use descriptive anchor text and point to the correct destinations.
☐	Images that matter to understanding the page have useful alt text; decorative images are treated as decorative.
☐	Structured data, when used, matches the visible page content and the type of page being marked up.
☐	The site's key service/product/location pages are internally linked from relevant pages.

4. Responsive and mobile QA

Do not approve a launch from a desktop screenshot alone. Test the tasks people actually perform.

	Checklist item
☐	Navigation works on a narrow phone viewport without clipped menus or unreachable controls.
☐	Text remains readable without horizontal scrolling.
☐	Buttons and form controls are usable with touch.
☐	Images, videos, tables, embeds, and maps resize or scroll appropriately.
☐	Sticky headers, banners, popups, and cookie notices do not cover important content or controls.
☐	Forms can be completed comfortably on mobile keyboards.
☐	Phone/email/map links perform the intended action on a mobile device.
☐	The menu can be opened, closed, and navigated with keyboard and touch.

5. Forms and conversion paths

Forms are part of the application, not just page decoration. Test the full trip from typing to the final notification or CRM record.

	Checklist item
☐	Every production form has a clear purpose and a visible success state.
☐	Required fields are actually enforced.
☐	Validation messages explain what needs fixing.
☐	Invalid input does not erase information the visitor already entered unnecessarily.
☐	Successful submissions reach the intended destination: email inbox, CRM, database, ticketing system, or other workflow.
☐	Autoresponders or confirmation messages use correct business information.
☐	Spam protection works without blocking normal users.
☐	Duplicate submissions are handled sensibly.
☐	Form events are tracked once and only once in analytics.
☐	Test submissions have been removed from production systems where appropriate.

6. Analytics, tags, and measurement

Launch day is too late to discover that the site was collecting pageviews but not recording leads.

	Checklist item
☐	The production analytics property is the one intended for this business.
☐	Analytics tags load only on the production domain(s) where they are supposed to.
☐	Tag Manager containers are the correct production container and version.
☐	Key conversion events have been tested end to end.
☐	Form submissions, clicks, downloads, purchases, calls, bookings, or other business events are recorded according to the measurement plan.
☐	There is no duplicate installation that can double-count the same event.
☐	Consent settings behave as intended for the jurisdictions and tools the business uses.
☐	Search Console or equivalent webmaster tools are connected to the correct property.
☐	Someone on the team knows where to look when a conversion suddenly drops after launch.

7. Performance and Core Web Vitals

Performance is more than a Lighthouse score. Check the causes: oversized assets, slow servers, blocking JavaScript, layout shifts, and third-party code.

	Checklist item
☐	Hero images and other large assets are appropriately sized and compressed.
☐	Modern image formats are used where they make sense, without sacrificing needed quality.
☐	Below-the-fold images are lazy-loaded where appropriate.
☐	Critical fonts and styles do not create avoidable flashes or long rendering delays.
☐	Third-party scripts have a business reason; remove or defer scripts that are not needed at page load.
☐	Layout does not jump when images, fonts, ads, banners, or embeds finish loading.
☐	The most important interactive controls remain responsive while the page is loading.
☐	Core Web Vitals are checked with field or lab tooling, with special attention to LCP, INP, and CLS.

8. Security and production configuration

A launch checklist is not a penetration test, but it should catch common and preventable configuration mistakes.

	Checklist item
☐	HTTPS is enforced and certificates are valid.
☐	Admin, CMS, hosting, database, and third-party accounts use strong authentication and appropriate access.
☐	Unused test accounts, staging credentials, default passwords, and development endpoints are removed or protected.
☐	Secrets and API keys are not embedded in public client-side code when they need server-side protection.

	Checklist item
☐	Forms and APIs validate input server-side; client-side validation is not treated as the security boundary.
☐	File uploads are constrained to the types and sizes the application actually needs.
☐	Production error messages do not expose stack traces, credentials, internal paths, or sensitive configuration.
☐	Backups exist and the team knows how restoration would work.
☐	Security headers and platform-level protections have been reviewed for the actual hosting architecture.

9. Browser, device, and accessibility spot checks

You do not need every device in existence. You do need a deliberate sample that exposes common problems.

	Checklist item
☐	Latest major desktop browsers used by the audience have been tested.
☐	A current iPhone/Safari path and Android/Chrome path have been tested.
☐	Keyboard-only navigation has been tested through the main user journeys.
☐	Visible focus is clear enough to follow while tabbing.
☐	Images, links, forms, dialogs, and navigation have been checked for basic accessibility failures.
☐	Zooming/reflow has been tested rather than assuming the design is responsive.
☐	Motion, autoplay media, and animations have been checked for usability and reduced-motion behavior where relevant.

10. Infrastructure, DNS, and deployment

The website is not live just because the files are deployed. Make sure the domain, edge layer, cache, redirects, forms, and monitoring all agree about what “live” means.

	Checklist item
☐	DNS records point to the intended hosting platform.
☐	The correct production environment—not a preview build—is serving the domain.
☐	CDN/cache behavior has been checked after deployment.
☐	Environment variables and server configuration are present in production.
☐	A known good deployment can be identified and rolled back if necessary.
☐	404s, 500s, failed function calls, and form errors are observable somewhere the team will actually see them.
☐	Deployment does not overwrite critical assets or files unexpectedly.

11. Final launch test

Run these tests after the final production build. Earlier staging tests do not replace a production check.

	Checklist item
☐	Open the homepage in a fresh browser session.

	Checklist item
☐	Complete the primary conversion path exactly as a new visitor would.
☐	Submit every important form once with valid information and once with an obvious error.
☐	Open every main navigation item and a sample of footer/resource links.
☐	Test one old URL that should redirect and one nonexistent URL that should reach the 404 page.
☐	Confirm analytics and the most important conversion event appear in the appropriate reports/debug tools.
☐	Check robots.txt, sitemap.xml, canonical URLs, and noindex directives on representative pages.
☐	Check the contact phone/email/address from a real visitor's perspective.
☐	Verify the live page source and network behavior for any critical script or API dependency.
☐	Have another person perform the core task without coaching. Note anything they hesitate about.

12. First 24-72 hours after launch

The first review after launch is where you learn what production users are actually experiencing.

	Checklist item
☐	Check traffic, conversions, form submissions, error rates, and top landing pages against normal expectations.
☐	Review Search Console or equivalent tools for crawl errors, indexing anomalies, or unexpected URL changes.
☐	Watch server, CDN, function, form, and API logs for failures that did not appear in testing.
☐	Look for sudden changes in page speed or Core Web Vitals after production traffic arrives.
☐	Review the site's most important conversion path on a real phone and desktop again.
☐	Fix high-impact launch defects promptly and document what changed.
☐	Record the final production commit/build/version and deployment date.
☐	Schedule the first routine post-launch review rather than treating launch as the end of QA.

Launch sign-off

I have verified the production site against this checklist, documented any accepted exceptions, and confirmed who owns post-launch monitoring.

Owner: _____

Approved on: _____

Accepted exceptions / follow-up work:

Reference material: Google Search Essentials; Google Search Console documentation; web.dev Core Web Vitals; OWASP Top 10:2025; W3C Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2.

Sources: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/essentials> | <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/monitor-debug/search-console-start> | <https://web.dev/articles/vitals> | <https://top10.owasp.org/2025/> | <https://www.w3.org/TR/wcag/>